

St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 10, Jan 11/24 2021 Sunday After Theophany

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http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-010_2021-01-24+theophany.doc http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-010_2021-01-24+theophany.html http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-010_2021-01-24+theophany.pdf

Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter on at least the first and the 15th of each month. This is the 10th sent to 75 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need anything.

Questions about Theophany

This is a quiz! Don't cheat! Really! Try to answer the questions, THEN look at the answers. Do it! Do it now!

The answers are at the end of the newsletter. Please write to us with any questions or comments.

QUESTION 1 When is Theophany celebrated? What does it commemorate? What is another name for this feast?

QUESTION 2 Retell the story of the Baptism of Christ. Which Evangelists report it?

QUESTION 3 Why was Christ baptized?

QUESTION 4 What happened immediately after the Lord's Baptism? What can we infer from this?

QUESTION 5 Where did the Lord go after His Baptism? What happened? What may we infer from this? Another significant event occurred while the Lord was away. What was it?

QUESTION 6 Why did St John the Baptist baptize?

QUESTION 7 What significant event in Israel points to baptism? Are there others?

QUESTION 8 Name at least five Theophanies in the Old Testament and one besides the Baptism of the Lord in the NT

QUESTION 9 The pastor visits the homes of all his parishioners and the days shortly following. Why? How should one make ready for this visit?

QUESTION 10 What is the fasting typicon for every day from Nativity up to and including Theophany?

A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 30-35

30. When you pray, let no one notice your tears of compunction or zeal for salvation, except God Himself.

31. Revere Orthodox Priests as Angelic heralds of good tidings, sent to gladden the faithful and bring you salvation.

32. Treat others with the respect due heirs of the celestial kingdom, yet with the caution you would employ handling fire.

33. Forgive everything and empathize with all men in their sufferings.

34. Do not be obsessed with yourself like a hen with an egg she has just laid, but take thought for your neighbor.

35. The Holy Spirit flees the man who seeks an easy, tranquil life.

Prison Ministry News



We have some good news for you! By the time you get this newsletter, we probably will have purchased the property in Marshall. Archbishop Peter has given us a blessing to form a mission there. For now, the bottom floor will be the church, and the upper floor will be apartments. We are going to start small. Jude Thaddeus, who lives there, will be doing reader services every Saturday and Sunday, and Fr David and I plan to come at least once a month each to celebrate evening services and the liturgy. We are taking an approach of "if we build it, they will come."

How is this facility going to help people from prison? We don't know exactly yet, but in the beginning, we plan to try to attract a couple of stable people to stay and live there as a community. We would then be able to accept one parolee at a time. We hope that they would find work doing some of the industry that Jude Thaddeus is doing or around town because Marshall has a pretty good economy. We hope that we get people situated and then they would move to an apartment or something, and then another person could come in. This might sound like very little to you, but it is a beginning.

The problem with having a house that multiple parolees can come into is that, first of all, there's an enormous amount of red tape. Second of all, there's a tremendous amount of supervision needed, and you guys know what can happen. Sometimes people getting out of prison still have a prison mentality, and we don't want to have a problem of having to deal with four or five people that are not quite ready for prime time.

We plan only to accept Orthodox Christians to live in the house, with the recommendation of at least two priests. It just so happens that we have two priests involved in prison ministry, so we've got that part handled. Since we accept one person at a time, there is no limitation regarding the type of offense.



Maybe in the future, we will be able to have a halfway house. But we don't have the personnel or the legal expertise to do this yet. Please pray for this endeavor to succeed. It is a small beginning, but an oak grows from a tiny acorn.

Questions and Answers

Regarding the use of Roman Catholic prayers: Don't use any of their unique prayers or prayer rules. In the example you provided, and in others I have read, there is some influence or reflection of their erroneous theology, and a certain unguarded sentimentality which is not in keeping with the self-reproach and humility characteristic of Orthodox prayers and piety. What is particularly odd about the Chaplet of Divine Mercy prayer you quoted is the phrase, "I offer you the Body, Blood, Divinity, and Soul of your dearly beloved Son" - this offering implies a liturgical, sacramental action of one who has been clothed in the grace of the priesthood; additionally, the division of Christ's members in this descriptive form is also strange, since we worship and glorify the whole God-Man Jesus Christ and do not separate Him in our thoughts or dogmatic expressions into disconnected parts (thus the strangeness of the "Sacred Heart of Jesus" adoration common among Catholics). It is not the sort of

prayer a layperson should offer, or that any Orthodox person need offer. This is just one example.

Hold fast to the traditions you have received in the Orthodox Church; enter into Her worship, prayer, and theology more deeply. There are no greater, more edifying, and instructive prayers than those which the Church provides us; truly, the Jesus Prayer alone is of supreme beauty and power when prayed with a humble, obedient, and penitential heart. Use your Orthodox prayer book, and explore the richness of its contents through frequent practice and careful attentiveness.

Regarding the performance of your prayer rule, including bows and prostrations, in the sight of others in the dorm, and their comments accusing you of phariseism for your public prayer: Let's imagine for a moment that one of your neighbors in a cell or dorm came up to you and said, "Why do you use the toilet when I'm watching? Why do you shower in front of me? You're a pervert." Wouldn't you rightly say, "I don't

have a choice in the matter; if I could do these things privately, I would." That may be a crude example, but it illustrates the point.

Prayer is not optional: it is a necessity, moreso even than attending to our bodily health and hygiene. We are commanded to enter our closet - that is, go into a place unseen by men - when we pray, and not to pray on street corners in order to be seen of men. When possible, we should fulfill this rule. When we can't, we should still pray, sign the cross, venerate our icons, engage our body and soul in service to God - giving our attention and whole heart to God, and leaving to His will, and to the will of our neighbor,

what the reaction will be. If your intent is not to be seen but to offer obedience and reverence to God and His Holy Ones, you cannot be held at fault for the bad thoughts of others. You can answer any sincere questions and explain your practices more thoroughly to those who wish to understand, but say little or nothing when derision or mockery are directed toward you, so as to avoid the traps of bitterness, anger, and pride. Just think, "They're right- I'm a hypocrite and a Pharisee: God, be merciful to me, a sinner!"

Rev. David Companik

St. Theophan the Recluse: Progressive Ravings and the Theoretical Mindset

From "The Spiritual Life, chapters 16 and 17

What has happened to you? What kinds of questions are these? "I do not know what to do with my life. Should I be doing something in particular? Should I define some particular purpose for myself?" I read this, and I was dumbfounded; where could such odd thoughts have come from? Indeed, you already settled all of this when you expressed the desire to stand at the level of human dignity.

I would guess that among your friends are progressive thinkers or that you have joined a society having such people in it, and they have scattered your good sense. Such people usually rave in this manner.

It seems to me that all of this is clear and simple; there is no reason to torture yourself with difficult problems. You need to put out of your mind any plans about "multi-beneficial, all-embracing, common-to-all mankind" activity such as the progressives rant about.

Phrases such as "the good of mankind" and "the good of the people" are always on their tongues...the progressives have in mind all mankind or at least all of its people lumped together. Probably you, after hearing so many profound ideas, were captivated by them, and when you turned your eyes to your real life, you saw with regret that you had vegetated in your family circle without benefit or purpose. Oh! Only now has someone opened your eyes!

The fact is, however, that "mankind" or "the people" does not exist as a person for whom you could do something right now. **It consists of individual persons. By doing something for one person, we are doing it within the general mass of humanity.**

If each one of us did what was possible to do for whoever was standing right in front of our eyes, instead of goggling at the community of mankind, then all people, in aggregate, would at each moment be doing that which is needed by those in need, and by satisfying their needs, would

establish the welfare of all mankind, which is made up of haves and have-nots, the weak and the strong. But those who keep thoughts of the welfare of all mankind inattentively let slip by that which is in front of their eyes. Because they do not have the opportunity to perform a general work, and let slip by the opportunity to perform a particular work, they accomplish nothing towards the main purpose of life.

I was told of such an instance in St. Petersburg. There was some sort of meeting of young people who were advocates of universal welfare – this was at the very height of the progressive raving. One gentleman was making an impassioned speech about love for mankind and the people. Everyone was enraptured.

But when he returned home, his servant did not open the door quickly enough – he had not seen him coming. The servant did not give him a candle quickly enough, something had happened to his pipe, and it was a little cold in his room. Our philanthropist could not stand this, and finally he sharply reprimanded his servant. The latter answered something back, and the former struck him in the chest. And so here is our fine fellow who was overflowing with love toward mankind in one place, who could not behave properly toward even one person at home.

Also, at the very height of progressive raving, there were some pretty girls who threw themselves into the work of bookbinding establishments, who often left their mothers without a crust of bread. All the same, they imagined that they were in some way moving forward and establishing the happiness of mankind.

All troubles come from a mental outlook that is too broad. It is better to humbly cast your eyes down toward your feet, and to figure out which step to take where. This is the truest path.

<https://www.pravmir.com/st-theophan-the-recluse-progressive-ravings-and-the-theoretical-mindset/>

Masha the Fool: A Touching Story about Selfless Love

Masha has died in a fire. It would be more appropriate to call her Maria since she was already in her sixties when she died. But everyone at Fr Eugene's parish called her Mashka without ceremony and considered her a local lunatic.

Masha spent all her time in the church. She did not stay at the services much; instead, she played with the children in the courtyard. Sometimes they would even give her communion without confession as if she was a child. In fact, her behavior really was like a little girl's.

The adult parishioners didn't exactly use to dislike her; rather, they simply avoided her. She was very clingy, constantly annoying people with

hugs, begging for something, or simply talking incessantly. She often complained about things. It could be a hole in her tights, someone offending her, or the priest having scolded her.

Father Eugene loved her, though. He only asked her not to get in the way during the service.

"Be quiet, Mashka! It's the Cherubic hymn already!" some told her.

"Here, take the candy and go, let me pray," – others said, pushing her to the exit, and she sadly walked away with her head down. But then she would see the children in the courtyard and light up, instantly giving away the earned candy.

The church kids considered Masha an equal and hung on her in bunches.

Together they played hide and seek, tag and dolls; she sculpted Easter cakes in the sandbox with them and read them nursery rhymes. There was nothing she enjoyed more than pushing someone's stroller with a baby around the courtyard. She was sometimes trusted with that. Masha then walked with her carriage both proudly and timidly, making frequent stops to look inside the stroller. She looked at babies with indescribable tenderness and a kind of deep longing, as if this ailing woman's soul was crying over her unfulfilled motherhood.

She also had a great love for the Mother of God. Once, a miraculous icon of the Mother of God was brought to their church for just one day. People were coming all day to venerate it. At some point, an important-looking, fashionable, and very fragrant lady approached the icon. For some reason Mashka started tugging at her sleeve and laughing. "Leave me alone, you fool!" The woman exclaimed angrily, "Can someone take her away?" Father Eugene heard this. "The Mother of God came to the fools also," he said quietly. The lady was taken aback, but Masha was taken aback even more. She became very serious, knelt in front of the icon, bowed, and quietly left.

After that, she sometimes stood for a long time in front of some image of the Mother of God, looking at the One who came to her, although she was only a "local fool." So, she would stand thinking about something... And now she is gone.

It happened after the service. Masha went about her business. As she was passing some building, she saw that one of the apartments was on fire.

The firemen had already evacuated the residents when she heard some little boy crying at the top of his voice, "My kitten Fluffy is still there!" His mother was holding him tightly against her while he kept screaming and



screaming. Then, according to the eyewitnesses, Masha rushed into the entrance. "Where, you going, fool?" They tried to stop her, "You are going to die!" But she didn't listen. It is hard to believe, but Masha did find the kitten, but she died in intensive care from carbon monoxide poisoning.

There was no one to bury her, so the parish took over everything. After the funeral service, someone said, "It's sad to die like that, out of foolishness." "It's not out of foolishness that she died, but out of love." Father Eugene answered.

And he told us something that no one knew except him. Masha was still a healthy little girl when she climbed a tall tree to rescue a kitten that got stuck there. She did rescue the kitten, but she fell and injured her head. The doctors tried to cure her, but nothing came of it. Masha remained a child for the rest of her life. She became that goofy Mashka, who was never taken seriously by anyone. But she loved and pitied all living creatures and was adored by children, who cannot be fooled, you know.

"Yes, she died because of her love," Father Eugene repeated, "God rest the soul of Your servant Maria."

Translated by The Catalogue of Good Deeds

Source: <https://prihozhnin.msdm.ru/home/podumat/o-spasenii/1502-o-mashke-durochke.html>

Theophany, The Baptism of the Lord, & "Illumining." "To Fulfil all Righteousness."

In the name of the Father and of the Son and the Holy Spirit. Amen. Today we celebrate a day called by many names: the baptism of our Lord, Theophany, and it is also called "Illumining." We commemorate our Lord's Baptism today in Jordan. Theophany is the appearance of God, where indeed the Holy Trinity manifested Himself after Our Lord's Baptism. Why would we call it Illumining? It is because, through baptism, we are indeed illuminated.

God had a plan for man. The primeval plan was for us to grow in knowledge and wisdom, according to how we could bear it, in purity, without any knowledge of evil at all. But man didn't choose that plan. So God, in His wisdom knowing this, sent His only-begotten Son.

Salvation is the knowledge of God, but only the pure can know the pure. We can even see this in our daily lives. We don't completely understand some people, and we know this because we know that they're somehow purer and humbler than us. And we think: "I don't understand how that person can take such abuse from her husband, or his son, or his co-worker, or some other person, and be so humble about it." We know people like that. Hopefully, some people speak about us in those kinds of tones because we are supposed to be a light to the rest of the world.

Only the pure can know the pure. But we're dirty, and we need purification. And what's more, we don't have any way to become pure. We don't have any way to clean ourselves. And our flesh, what is more, wars against us. Even if we wished to cleanse ourselves (and we don't have the

means, without God's help, mind you), we cannot. We don't have the strength, the ability; we don't have the knowledge, we don't have the grace. We cannot understand God without Him revealing himself to us. So, that is why our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ came incarnate of a Virgin, into the midst of us - to invigorate us and make us able to live, but not only that; also, to give us an example.

His ministry was two-fold. Being God, He taught us all the necessary things for our salvation by His example, how He lived, how He spoke, and His demeanor. And He transmitted this faithfully and carefully to His disciples. This mind of Christ is only found in the Orthodox faith, and it has been transmitted carefully and perfectly, throughout the ages, by the Church.

He showed us not only by His teaching but also by how He lived. And He was a man, as well as being God, so He was subject to the things we are subject to, even unto death. Therefore, because He subjected himself to Baptism, He commanded the church with authority: "Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and the Holy Spirit." He was not the kind of leader, or the kind of king, who would tell his subjects to do something that He wasn't willing to do.

He will do more for us expects more of Himself than He requires of us. And indeed, that is a principle of leadership. Whether a father, mother, priest, employer or a teacher, a leader must lead by being selfless and emptying himself as Christ emptied Himself.

Today we have a fantastic thing before us. He who created the waters submits to being baptized in them. He who created the heavens and the earth and saw that it was good and not any whit evil submits to apparent cleansing in waters. He Who is the Regenerator regenerates our flesh; He descends in the flesh into waters and makes them regenerating. And he does this to show us how necessary it is for baptism.

To know Christ, we must be like Him. You cannot know somebody unless you become like that person - it is not possible. Our Christian life in the flesh is to try to acquire the virtues, to be a good husbandman, to acquire the Holy Spirit, as my patron, St. Seraphim of Sarov, said, "By fasting, by diligence, by care, by prayers, by weeping, by repentance, by the whole Christian life." That is the whole reason for ascetical exercises. It's not because they're rules to be followed. It's because they are LIFE!

A man who sees a way of life that leads to eternal life would be crazy, blind, not to follow such a life. Our Lord taught us many principles of how to live, but the essential aspect of His ministry is that *He made us ABLE to live this way*. I can tell you many things about the Church's teaching, but I cannot invigorate you or make you able to live this way. That is only possible through your submission to the God-man Jesus Christ and the All-Holy Holy Trinity, Who makes a man able to live.

Baptism is an image of death and life. When we descend into the waters, we die; our old man, with its lusts, dies in the waters. When we ascend out of the waters, we are reborn as a new creature. This is a hard thing to understand. We cannot fathom it. We do not know how a man is reborn of water and the Spirit; we just know that because of this rebirth, it is possible to live the Christian life.

Baptism is the first mystery, although perhaps one should say the first mystery is the incarnation of the Son of God, which made everything else possible. Our entrance into the Christian life is through baptism. Without it, we're not able to progress one wit in the knowledge of God. And the knowledge of God IS salvation! But remember, one cannot progress in the knowledge of God without progressing in purity at the same time.

We have no "armchair theologians" in the Orthodox Church. He is a theologian - who studies God - lives as God commands him to live, and is enlightened. The church has known theologians that have not been able to read or write. Or even, and this is hard for us in our industrialized society to understand, they might not even have been intelligent, as we would think of intelligence. But they were wise in the ways of God because they lived a life in accordance with His grace.

We must understand now why our Lord was baptized. He did not need to be baptized. What does it say after He was baptized? "Straightway He came up out of the water." For the church, the reason is crystal clear, and therefore it will be apparent to us now. He came straightway out of the water because He has no sin. In those days, St. John was baptizing for repentance, a baptism of repentance, but not for remission of sins because he cannot remit sins. People would be baptized, and they came up partway and confessed their sins right then and there. And then they were released out of the water. That's how it was done. But our Lord did not need to do so; He had no sins to confess. When He went into the water, the demons fled. The icon of our Lord's baptism shows the demons fleeing from the water because they could not bear to be in the same place as the God-man Jesus Christ.

How can anyone stand against this mystery when our Lord endorses it so emphatically? Let's take a look, a little bit, at the short scriptures we read at the liturgy. "Then cometh Jesus from Galilee to Jordan unto John to be baptized of Him. But John forbade Him, saying, "I have need to be

baptized of Thee, and comest thou to me?" And Jesus said unto him, "suffer it to be so now, for thus it becometh us to fulfill all righteousness."

It's a little bit of a riddle; what is He talking about, "all righteousness?" The Lord did not need baptism or anything else to act upon Him to be righteous. He could save His human flesh by His own ability, but our human flesh requires baptism. He was baptized to change the nature of water so that, in those who believe, and by the grace of God, in the church, it can make a person capable of being saved, that is, to be perfected and know God intimately. We can therefore give a free paraphrase of our Lord's words as "Suffer it to be so now, because, without baptism, you cannot become righteous."

It was also a strong tradition, a God-inspired tradition, of the Jewish people, that when a prophet said something, you did it! Jesus obeyed a prophet. John was the greatest of the prophets; our Lord Himself said so. He obeyed a prophet by being baptized, showed us an example, and later, after His resurrection, a command to be baptized.

Our Lord does not tell us to do anything we are not capable of doing. He does not ask us to do anything in the flesh that we cannot do and that He did not already do in the flesh. He told us that our flesh should become pure. His flesh was always pure; He made His flesh completely invigorated with the Godhead. And indeed, that will happen to us because He did it to Himself. He promises us that we will rise from the dead. Since He did it to Himself, we are capable. He commands us to be baptized; He did it himself. He turned the other cheek when he was slapped by the arrogant Pharisees and their henchman, the Roman soldiers. And He commands us to turn our cheek when we are slapped. He commands us to forgive, and He forgave.

There is no commandment that the Lord gave that He did not fulfill Himself in the flesh. And He even told us to be perfect, and He was perfect - in the flesh and as God. We can do all those things because He did them for us and made us able to do them. He led by example, and He led by power and grace and mercy.

"Then He suffered Him. And Jesus, when He was baptized, went up straightway out of the waters and lo! The heavens were opened unto Him, and He saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and lighting upon Him. And a voice from heaven saying, "This is my beloved Son in whom I am well-pleased."

We already said what it means that He went "straightway out of the water." John was in the water trembling, as a man before God. And God comes out of the water, and the Holy Spirit descends upon His shoulder, Jesus' shoulder, so as not to confuse the two. And the voice says, "This is my son, in whom I am well-pleased."

And the heavens are opened. Why? Because the heavens are opened to us through baptism. And also, the heavens are opened to us through something else. Right away after the Baptism, St. Mark barely catches his breath, I don't think he even has to dip his pen again in ink, and he starts to write, "and straightway He was led out by the Spirit into the wilderness for 40 days."

There is a reason why he writes with such haste, doesn't even finish talking about baptism and wham! He is talking about Jesus being tempted in the wilderness because this happens to us. Right after our Baptism, we are tempted. During the whole of our life, we're tempted, and sometimes we feel that we are in a barren place, a rocky desert, with no water and no comfort, and we sometimes get despondent. Our Lord had the same things happen to Him; He became hungry as a man, tired as a man, He wept as a

man. And right after His Baptism, He shows that we should expect that we are in a life-or-death struggle.

Immediately upon being baptized, we are enlisted as soldiers. Not as conscripts, mind you, but as willing men, willing to put on the armor of faith and righteousness. We are eager to fight the good fight because we had stated so, whether it was as an infant when our sponsors spoke for us, and we grew to maturity, and we learned of the church, or whether it is, in

the case of most of us, where we spoke for ourselves and agreed to the tenets of the Christian faith before we were thrust down into the water and out of it three times.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/sermons/feasts-of-the-savior-theophany-03_1999.html

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/sermons/feasts-of-the-savior-theophany-03_1999.doc

Royal Hours of Theophany. Troparion of the pre-festival – Tone 4. Whereby we cross the flowing stream of life.

The River Jordan was once turned back by the mantle of Elisha /

when Elijah had been taken up, /

and the waters were divided hither and thither. /

And for Him the watery path became dry, /

Verily as a type of baptism, /

Whereby we cross the flowing stream of life. //

Christ hath appeared in the Jordan to sanctify the waters.

This Troparion is sung at each of the Royal Hours of Theophany. It describes an event that is a “type” or foreshadowing of baptism. Many Theophany hymns describe the many types of baptism in the Old Testament. A “type” is an event or thing which foreshadows or “points to” a future event or thing. A good rule of thumb regarding typology is that the more types there are for something, the more important it is. There are many types for baptism, the cross, and the resurrection, for example.

The dividing of the River Jordan when the mantle of Elisha struck it is an obvious type of baptism since it evokes the memory of the dividing of the Red sea, which is perhaps the quintessential and most important type of baptism in the Old Testament.

This event has a nuance to it that the dividing of the Red Sea does not have. When Christ was baptized in the same Jordan waters divided by Elisha’s mantle, “the Jordan turned back and fled” from the God-man Jesus Christ.

If you listen carefully to our hymns, you will see that they mix typology, history, dogma, and moral instruction quite freely. The most important part of the hymn is at the end when we sing:

Whereby we cross the flowing stream of life. //

Christ hath appeared in the Jordan to sanctify the waters.

Here is the moral connection that I talk about so often. Our Lord’s baptism “sanctified the waters”, that is, changed the nature of water so that the waters of baptism can enable our nature to live victoriously and to

become perfect. Whatever happens to us -- with baptism, we will be able to “cross the flowing stream of life” and find perfect rest. Baptism is not just an event. It is active throughout all of our “flowing stream of life.”

As in the parting of the Red Sea, the parting of the Jordan indicates that baptism is active at the beginning of our new life, in the middle (as we cross the flowing stream of life), and at the end, when we reach the other side. The waters are a wall of protection and also of guidance.

When we hear this hymn, we should feel the moral implications of baptism. The God-man Jesus Christ made our humanity capable of perfection so that we could know perfection – God, and in baptism, He provided the means of this change.

And Eliu said to him, Stay here, I pray thee, for the Lord has sent me to Jordan. And Elisaie said, As the Lord lives and thy soul lives, I will not leave thee: and they both went on. (7) And fifty men of the sons of the prophets *went also*, and they stood opposite afar off: and both stood on *the bank* of Jordan. (8) And Eliu took his mantle, and wrapped it together, and smote the water: and the water was divided on this side and on that side, and they both went over on dry ground. (9) And it came to pass while they were crossing over, that Eliu said to Elisaie, Ask what I shall do for thee before I am taken up from thee. And Elisaie said, Let there be, I pray thee, a double *portion* of thy spirit upon me. (10) And Eliu said, Thou hast asked a hard thing: if thou shalt see me when I am taken up from thee, then shall it be so to thee; and if not, it shall not be so. (11) And it came to pass as they were going, they went on talking; and, behold, a chariot of fire, and horses of fire, and it separated between them both; and Eliu was taken up in a whirlwind as it were into heaven. (12) And Elisaie saw, and cried, Father, father, the chariot of Israel, and the horseman thereof! And he saw him no more: and he took hold of his garments, and rent them into two pieces. (13) And Elisaie took up the mantle of Eliu, which fell from off him upon Elisaie; and Elisaie returned, and stood upon the brink of Jordan; (14) and he took the mantle of Eliu, which fell from off him, and smote the water, and said, Where is the Lord God of Eliu? and he smote the waters, and they were divided hither and thither; and Elisaie went over. **(2Ki 2:6-14 Brenton, or 4 Kings, Sept, read during the Vespertine Divine Liturgy on the Eve of Theophany)** Source: <http://www.orthodox.net/journal/royal-hours-of-theophany-troparion-of-the-pre-festival-tone-4-whereby-we-cross-the-flowing-stream-of-life.html>

Answers to Questions about Theophany

ANSWER 1 The feast of Theophany is Jan 6 (Jan 19 on the civil calendar). It commemorates the Baptism of our Lord Jesus Christ and much more, as its name implies. The word "Theophany" means a "manifestation of God." This is similar to another word by which this feast is known, "Epiphany," which means "manifestation."

We celebrate the Baptism of Jesus Christ as a Theophany because, after His baptism in the Jordan, the Holy Trinity was made manifest: "And Jesus, when he was baptized, went up straightway out of the water: and, lo, the heavens were opened unto Him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon Him: {17} And lo a voice from heaven, saying, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased." (Mat 3:16-17)

ANSWER 2 All four Evangelists report the Baptism of Christ and its precursor, the preaching and baptizing of the Holy Prophet and Forerunner and Baptist John.

Ministry of St John the Baptist: Matthew 3:1-12, Mark 1:1-8, Luke 3:1-20, John 1:19-34 **Baptism of Christ:** Matthew 3:13-17, Mark 1:9-11, Luke 3:21-22, John 1:29-34

The story is very simple. The Holy Prophet and Forerunner and Baptist John was preaching repentance and baptizing in the Jordan. His ministry was preparing the hearts of the people for Christ. Jesus came upon him one day and asked to be baptized. The Holy Prophet was filled with fear and in humility told that Lord that he needed to be baptized, not Jesus. Jesus told John to "suffer it to be so now, to fulfill all righteousness." The Lord was then baptized (immersed) in the waters of the Jordan, and upon coming out of the water, He saw the "heavens opened," and a voice was heard from heaven, which said, "Thou art my beloved Son, in Whom I am well pleased," and a dove descended upon Him.

ANSWER 3 *Why was Jesus baptized?* Our Lord answers this question: "Suffer it to be so now: for thus it becometh us to fulfill all righteousness." (Matthew 3:15)

Jesus does not need the Baptism of John, which was a baptism of repentance. (Matthew 3:11, and elsewhere). Neither did He need Christian Baptism, which is the renewal of man and the making of a new creature. The God-man is totally sinless and in no need of renewal.

The Holy Fathers tell us that "Righteousness" means the law. Christians are not exempt from the law's requirements since Jesus Christ came to fulfill the law and not destroy it. (Matt 5:17). Human nature was accursed because it could not fulfill the law. Baptism delivers human nature from the curse, and we are made able to reach God, know Him, and become like Him in moral purity. Our baptism makes us capable of being wholly delivered from the curse of sin, therefore, to "fulfill all righteousness." (See Bl. Theophylact, commentary on Matt 3:15)

Our Lord also was baptized as an example for us, to point out the necessity of baptism for man. There is no requirement that He has made for us that He did not fulfill Himself, including Baptism. He did everything as a man that He requires of us, as men. He who endured smiting and spitting and torment for our salvation demands of us that we turn the other cheek when our enemy smites us. He Who prayed with fervor in the depth of the night demands of us that we pray without ceasing. He Who brought all things before His Father and even the horrible specter of His impending death demands us to ask concerning all our needs. He Who submitted in all things to His Father demands that we pray, "Thy will be done" concerning

all things in our life. He Who submitted Himself to baptism demands of us that we are born again, of water and the spirit.

"With the servants the Lord, with the criminals the Judge, cometh to be baptized. But be not thou troubled; for in these humiliations His exaltation doth most shine forth. For He who vouchsafed to be borne so long in a Virgin's womb, and to come forth thence with our nature, and to be smitten with rods, and crucified, and to suffer all the rest which He suffered; --why marvellest thou if He also vouchsafed to be baptized, and to come with the rest to His servant. For the amazement lay in that one thing, that being God, He would be made Man, but the rest afar this all follows in the course of reason." (St John Chrysostom, Homilies on Matthew, Homily 22, Matthew 3:11)

"For *righteousness is the fulfilling of the commandments*. 'Since then we have performed all the rest of the commandments,' saith He, 'and this alone remains, it also must be added: because I am come to do away the curse that is appointed for the transgression of the law. I must therefore first fulfill it all, and having delivered you from its condemnation, in this way bring it to an end. It becometh me, therefore, to fulfill the whole law, by the same rule that it becometh me to do away the curse that is written against you in the law: this being the very purpose of my assuming flesh, and coming hither.'" (Ibid.)

ANSWER 4 *What happened immediately after the Lord's Baptism?* "And Jesus, when he was baptized, went up straightway out of the water: and, lo, the heavens were opened unto Him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon Him: {17} And lo a voice from heaven, saying, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased." (Mat 3:16-17)

The heavens were opened to show us that our baptism will open the heavens for us. God is made accessible to us. We can know the Unknowable. We can be changed. A good work is begun in us, and we have the means to have the promise fulfilled in us: "He which hath begun a good work in you will perform it until the day of Jesus Christ" (Phil 1:6)

We can only appropriate this promise if we look up unto heavenly things and leave off earthly and corruptible things. "Wherefore were the heavens opened? To inform thee that at thy baptism also this is done, God, calling thee to thy country on high, and persuading thee to have nothing to do with earth." (St John Chrysostom, Homilies on Matthew, op. cit.)

The Holy Spirit descended to show that He Who is baptized is greater than John, who baptized. It is He Who will baptize with the Holy Spirit and with fire. (Matthew 3:11) When the voice came from heaven, the presence of the dove over Christ made it clear that the words were applied to the God-man and not to His servant, John. "The Spirit came in the form of a dove, drawing the voice towards Jesus, and making it evident to all, that this was not spoken of John that baptized, but of Jesus Who was baptized." (St John Chrysostom, Homilies on Matthew, op. cit.) (See also Bl Theophylact, Commentary of Matthew)

ANSWER 5 After the Lord was baptized, "Then was Jesus led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil." (Mat 4:1). He was gone forty days and nights, during which time, He fasted. After this, the devil came to Him to tempt Him, offering Him three great temptations, which He easily overcame. It was also during this time that the Holy Prophet and Forerunner and Baptist John was put in prison, fulfilling the prophecy of John himself: "He must increase, but I must decrease." (John 3:30)

What are we to learn from the Lord's temptations, which followed immediately after His Baptism? After our baptism, we must expect temptations. Our baptism begins our battle, and we must never rest. We must never think of the Christian life in an intellectual way and must not be surprised when we encounter bitter temptations. No man can ascend unto dispassion and the knowledge of God without temptations. Can we expect to be left with no difficulties in this life, when the Lord Himself was troubled and buffeted? Our Lord warned us: "For if they do these things in a green tree, what shall be done in the dry?" (Luke 23:31)

Let us endure our temptations and ascend unto our destiny and purpose. " My brethren, count it all joy when ye fall into divers temptations; {3} Knowing this, that the trying of your faith worketh patience. {4} But let patience have her perfect work, that ye may be perfect and entire, wanting nothing." (James 1:2-4)

"For since with a view to our instruction He both did and underwent all things; He also endures to be led up thither, and to wrestle against the devil: so that each of those who are baptized, if after his baptism he has to endure greater temptations, may not be troubled as if the result were unexpected, but may continue to endure all nobly, as though it were happening in the natural course of things. " (St John Chrysostom, Homilies on Matthew, Homily 23, Matthew 4:1)

ANSWER 6 *Why did St John the Baptist baptize?* His entire ministry was to point towards Christ. He tells us why he baptized: "I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance: but He that cometh after me is mightier than I, whose shoes I am not worthy to bear: He shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost, and with fire" (Mat 3:11)

ANSWER 7 *What major event in Israel points to baptism?* The passage of the children of Israel through the Red Sea is a type of baptism.

Baptism is also alluded to in the magnificent event of the taking up of the Holy Prophet Elias in the chariot: "The river Jordan was once turned back by the mantle of Elisseus when Elias had been taken up, and the waters were divided hither and thither. And for Him, the watery path became dry, verily as a type of baptism, whereby we cross the flowing stream of life. Christ hath appeared in the Jordan to sanctify the waters." (Troparion of the Forefeast of Theophany. Tone 4)

"And it came to pass when they were gone over, that Elijah said unto Elisha, Ask what I shall do for thee, before I be taken away from thee. And Elisha said, I pray thee, let a double portion of thy spirit be upon me. {10} And he said, Thou hast asked a hard thing: nevertheless, if thou see me when I am taken from thee, it shall be so unto thee; but if not, it shall not be so. {11} And it came to pass, as they still went on, and talked, that, behold, there appeared a chariot of fire, and horses of fire, and parted them both asunder; and Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven. {12} And Elisha saw it, and he cried, My father, my father, the chariot of Israel, and the horsemen thereof. And he saw him no more: and he took hold of his own clothes, and rent them in two pieces. {13} He took up also the mantle of Elijah that fell from him, and went back, and stood by the bank of Jordan; {14} And he took the mantle of Elijah that fell from him, and smote the waters, and said, Where is the LORD God of Elijah? and when he also had smitten the waters, they parted hither and thither: and Elisha went over." (2 Kings 2:9-14)

ANSWER 8 *List some "Theophanies in Scripture."*

1. The Angel in the Furnace. The "angel of the Lord" in the furnace was a pre-incarnate manifestation of Jesus Christ.
2. The Three Angels who met Abraham. One of the angels was the "Angel of the Lord," a pre-incarnate manifestation of Jesus Christ.
3. *Moses seeing the "back parts" of God.* The "glory of the Lord" was the uncreated light streaming from the pre-incarnate Jesus Christ
4. *Moses and the burning bush.* The burning bush has two primary meanings. The first is that God was making himself manifest to Moses in the bush, and the flame was the uncreated light of God, which does not burn. The second is that the Bush represents the Theotokos, the Mother of God, who would bear Jesus Christ and not be "burned up."
5. *Jacob wrestling the angel.* The angel was, you guessed it, a pre-incarnate manifestation of Jesus Christ.
6. *Elias in the cave and the "still small voice."*

The Transfiguration of Christ. When Christ was transfigured on Mount Tabor, the cloud represented the Holy Spirit, and the voice of the Father completed an appearance of the Holy Trinity.

ANSWER 9 *Why do we bless homes after Theophany?* It is a long-standing tradition in Holy Orthodoxy that all the faithful' homes be blessed yearly, after the blessed feast of Theophany. The power of water to sanctify and transform is amply demonstrated in baptism, and we believe that God chooses to bless us through holy objects and actions, such as the relics of those who have pleased God, sacred icons, oil, and water.

The priest usually prays a short service of supplication and then blesses all living areas of the house with water while singing the Troparion for Theophany. In this way, the home of a Christian is "marked" and sanctified.

When the priest arrives, the home should be very clean and picked up. The doors to all rooms except the bathrooms should be open. It is good to have a small table set up, a cloth on it, and a candle. If the family has an icon of the Theophany, it can be placed there and any other well-loved icons in the family. The best place to put this table is before the family's icon corner.

ANSWER 10 *What foods do we eat after Nativity?* The Nativity of the Savior is such a joyous feast that all foods are allowed on the day of the feast and all days following, until the day before Theophany, which is a strict fast (if this day is Saturday or Sunday, wine and oil are allowed). On Theophany itself, of course, all foods are allowed. We fast the day before Theophany because we need to get ourselves prepared for the great feast. There is a time for feasting and a time for fasting. The time for fasting is before feasts, and the time for feasting is on the feast and afterward. The joy of Nativity leads us into the most extended non-fasting period in the church year, but we begin fasting the day before Theophany to be ready for yet another feast.